

Subject Code	MM501
Subject Title	Research Methods
Credit Value	3
Level	5
Normal Duration	1-semester
Pre-requisite/ Co-requisite/ Exclusion	Research and Consultancy Techniques for CRE (BRE501) and Business Research Methods (MM5011) and Marketing Research (MM586)
Objectives	This subject provides students with an opportunity to learn about the use of scientific research as a problem solving tool, and enables them to equip with the adequate knowledge and practical skills that are often required to conduct independent research in business and management fields. Specifically, this subject enables students: 1. To understand the processes of research in the management and operation of the public and private sectors, and the various approaches that are used in that research; 2. To critically review published material and other research and consultancy reports; 3. To equip with the necessary skills required to undertake a substantial supervised research project at a Master's degree level; 4. To experience the process of preparing a properly constructed proposal for a research project.
Intended Learning Outcomes	Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to: a. appreciate different research paradigms; b. formulate theoretically grounded research questions; c. exhibit skills essential to the planning and conduct of rigorous research; d. demonstrate familiarity with the concepts of validity and reliability in research; e. design appropriate sampling strategies, as well as collect, analyze and interpret data in diverse research settings; f. demonstrate a systematic understanding of the range of advanced research techniques, be able to critically evaluate these techniques and apply them appropriately; g. appraise the ethical implications of implementing research programmes; h. identify the range of channels for disseminating research and demonstrate the ability to communicate research findings effectively, both orally and in written form, to the business research and practitioner communities.
Subject Synopsis/ Indicative Syllabus	<u>Introduction to Research</u> Overview of management research: basic, applied and action research. Exploratory, descriptive and causal research. Evaluations studies. Basic research paradigms: positivism and the scientific method; phenomenology and qualitative methodologies. <u>The Research Process</u> The research process. The research proposal. <u>Research Problems and Literature Review</u> Identifying and defining a research topic: the literature review. <u>Theoretical Framework and Hypothesis Development</u> The nature of theory: concepts, variables, the theoretical framework, hypotheses; deduction and induction; the nature of causality in the social sciences; dependent and independent variables.

	<u>Measurement</u> Measurement: types of scales; concepts and their dimensions; variables; Likert and other scales; validity and reliability; use of existing scales. <u>Data Collection Methods and Sampling</u> Questionnaire design; ways of administering questionnaires; survey and sampling methods; causes of bias in surveys; causal and correlational studies; experimental designs; internal and external validity; quasi experiments. Exploratory research: reasons for and methods. Qualitative research: ethnography; grounded theory; problems of data collection and analysis; analytical versus statistical generalizability. Case study research: the study questions, propositions, units of analysis, criteria for interpreting the findings; qualitative and quantitative aspects; evaluation as an example of case studies. <u>Data Analysis and Interpretation</u> Data analysis and interpretation; basic concepts involved in statistical analysis; outline of the use of some multivariate statistics. <u>The Research Report</u> Purposes; audience; characteristics of a well-written report; integral parts of the report. <u>Research Ethics</u> The politics of management research; stakeholders; access to information. The ethics of management research; the PolyU’s requirements. Plagiarism in academic writing and how to avoid it.																																																																																								
Teaching/Learning Methodology	Lectures cover the core principles and concepts of the subject syllabus. Seminars are structured to enhance students’ understanding of relevant concepts through various kinds of activities, including presentation and discussion. Occasionally various staff members will visit the class to discuss on-going research projects with which they are involved.																																																																																								
Assessment Methods in Alignment with Intended Learning Outcomes	<table><tr><th rowspan="2">Specific assessment methods/tasks</th><th rowspan="2">% weighting</th><th colspan="8">Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)</th></tr><tr><th>a.</th><th>b.</th><th>c.</th><th>d.</th><th>e.</th><th>f.</th><th>g.</th><th>h.</th></tr><tr><td>Continuous Assessment*</td><td>100%</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>1. Individual assignment</td><td>20%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>2. Group reports</td><td>50%</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>3. Presentation</td><td>10%</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>4. Peer assessment</td><td>10%</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td>✓</td></tr><tr><td>5. Class participation</td><td>10%</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td>✓</td><td></td><td></td></tr><tr><td>Total</td><td>100 %</td><td colspan="8"></td></tr></table> <i>*Weighting of assessment methods/tasks in continuous assessment may be different, subject to each subject lecturer.</i>	Specific assessment methods/tasks	% weighting	Intended subject learning outcomes to be assessed (Please tick as appropriate)								a.	b.	c.	d.	e.	f.	g.	h.	Continuous Assessment*	100%									1. Individual assignment	20%	✓	✓							2. Group reports	50%	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	3. Presentation	10%								✓	4. Peer assessment	10%								✓	5. Class participation	10%						✓			Total	100 %								
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	To pass this subject, students are required to obtain Grade D or above in the overall subject grade. Explanation of the appropriateness of the assessment methods in assessing the intended learning outcomes: the various methods are designed to ensure that all students taking this subject – Individual assignment – Students are required to submit an individual work by addressing the core principles and concepts of the subject syllabus. Group reports and presentation – Students are required to prepare two interim reports, a final report, and present their work by applying their subject knowledge and demonstrating their research skills. Class participation – Feedback is given to students immediately following the presentations. All students are invited to join this discussion to demonstrate their understandings of the core principles and concepts of the subject syllabus.	
Student Study Effort Expected	Class contact:	
	▪ Lectures	39 Hrs.
	Other student study effort:	
	▪ Preparation for lectures	39 Hrs.
	▪ Preparation for assignment / group project and presentation	39 Hrs.
	Total student study effort	117 Hrs.
Reading List and References	<i>Recommended Textbook</i> Bougie, R., & Sekaran, U. (2020). <i>Research Methods for Business – A Skill Building Approach</i>. NY: John Wiley & Sons. <i>References</i> Bowerman, B. L., Drougas, A. M., Duckworth, W. M., Froelich, A. G., Hummel, R. M., Moninger, K. B., & Schur, P. J. (2019). <i>Business Statistics and Analytics in Practice</i>. NY: McGraw-Hill. Ghauri, P., Gronhaug, K., & Strange, R. (2020). <i>Research Methods in Business Studies</i>. UK: Cambridge University Press. Schindler, P. S. (2019). <i>Business Research Methods</i>. NY: McGraw-Hill. Yin, R. K. (2018). <i>Case Study Research and Applications: Design and Methods</i>. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE.	